

Chapter 14

Coming Full Circle—Forewords and Other Writings



It is often in composing introductions and overviews of larger works that we ultimately discover the essence of a work or a collection of works. This is why the closing chapter of this book is dedicated to the forewords of selected books that have been published by the Center for China and Globalization. These include both works by and compilations for top scholars like Joseph Nye, Graham Allison, Kishore Mahbubani, and Kerry Brown. Our goal in publishing these books was to provide Chinese readers with a better understanding and greater insights into the thoughts and perspectives of Western scholars on China.

However, including them here provides another layer of meaning, because by translating these into English, we not only revisit the key concepts proposed by these great scholars, but also provide readers outside of China with access to a perspective that targets Chinese readers. This unique take on familiar concepts is an important part of cross-cultural exchange, which is itself an integral part of CCG's mission.

By focusing on these broader themes and bringing them back to the forefront of the conversation, we can come away with the essential core concepts of the world's leading minds, which we can then gradually implement into our own practices, whether those be in business, academics, or government. Thus, by closing this book with a selection of forewords from other key works, we come full circle both in terms of key themes and important perspectives on central issues.

The first entry in this chapter is a translation of the foreword for the Chinese edition of Joseph Nye Jr.'s autobiography *A Life in the American Century*. In light of the increased influence of Asian countries, and China in particular, in global affairs, a number of scholars have begun to talk about the beginning of an Asian Century. Kishore Mahbubani is one of the main proponents of this concept. By looking back at the influence of the United States since the end of World War II, including both the positive and negative impacts it has had on world affairs, we are able to better analyze and observe a potential Asian Century and help the countries and leaders that will be consequential in how it takes shape.

A mirror of the first entry in this chapter, this second foreword comes from the translation of the Chinese version of Kishore Mahbubani's autobiography, aptly titled *Living in the Asian Century*. The difference is clear from the title, showing how Mahbubani believes that we are already living in the Asian Century, which he sees as an irreversible reality of today's world. His view is supported by the massive impact that countries like Japan, China, and ASEAN nations are having on the global economy as well as regional cooperation and how the traditions, values, and systems of these Asian nations will impact the future of global governance as well as how specific global issues are handled. Mahbubani provides interesting insights into many of the unique changes and challenges the world faces.

The third entry in this chapter is slightly different as it is meant as a guide for readers specifically for Henry Kissinger's masterwork *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy*. Because of the gap in understanding between China and the world in certain areas, it is sometimes helpful to provide a bit of background for readers interested in slightly more academic or technical works by Western scholars or experts. Kissinger's reflections on leadership are based on his interactions with and personal perspectives on a selection of six world leaders, including how they left their impact in history. Known as the "Master of Realism," Kissinger's analysis is full of practical elements that readers, whether they be scholars, entrepreneurs, diplomats, or private citizens, can apply in their professional and even private lives.

The next entry in this chapter takes an even broader perspective on relations between East and West. In this foreword for the Chinese translation of Kerry Brown's work *China Through European Eyes: 800 Years of Cultural and Intellectual Encounter*, we see how the current paradigm between Europe and China has taken shape over centuries, with accounts from travelers, traders, philosophers, and diplomats that have tried to explain and convey the subtleties of a culture very different from their own. As with the previous three entries, using the past as a mirror enables us to learn from those that came before, build on their successes, and possibly avoid their mistakes. Here, Brown makes an incredible contribution by increasing the size of that mirror exponentially.

The final entry in this chapter brings us to a core concept and one that is central to CCG's mission, my own personal vision, and a world in which everyone wins. This is the idea of the "positive-sum game," especially in the most decisive international relationship in the world today—the United States and China. This is a translation of the foreword of the Chinese edition of Joseph Nye Jr.'s seminal work *Soft Power and Great-Power Competition*, which examines how soft power, a term coined by Nye, is not a finite resource. The rise of China, especially in terms of its global influence and soft power, is not a threat to the United States and could even pay dividends for both countries if they can work on key global issues together. Professor Nye, a paragon in the field of great power relations, once again provides us with hope that the world can come to greater understanding through learning and with willingness to work together.

When the American Century Meets the Asian Century¹

Symbolic of the American Century, Professor Joseph Nye's own life embodied the American Dream and the socio-political dynamics of the 20th and 21st centuries. With personal anecdotes that provide deep insights, his book delves into the inner workings and logic of the American policy and the leaders behind it.

When Henry Luce, publisher of *Time* magazine, coined the term "American Century" in 1941, Joseph Nye Jr. was just four years old. It can be said that Professor Nye was born at the dawn of the American Century and grew up alongside it; his life and work is a vivid reflection of the American Century. His autobiography, *A Life in the American Century* is not only a personal memoir but also a "textbook on strategies" that decodes the evolution of international relations from the twentieth century to the early twenty-first century. In the book, Nye used the terms of each US president as chapter titles, blending his dual roles both in government and as an intellectual to seamlessly interweave grand narratives such as the Cold War, the globalization wave, the war against terrorism, and US-China competition and cooperation with his own academic and political endeavors. In the book, Nye avoided dry theoretical exposition, instead using vivid historical details—such as his efforts on nuclear non-proliferation during the Carter administration, his promotion of the "Nye Initiative" during the Clinton administration, his debates with Henry Kissinger, and his reflections on the concept of "soft power"—including many previously undisclosed details, to illustrate how a scholar shapes reality with his ideas.

For readers interested in international politics, this book offers an excellent chance to understand the evolution of US foreign policy, the rise and fall of great power hegemony, and the transformation of the global order. Over the past 80-plus years since World War II, the question "Is the American Century over?" has not only been a common concern worldwide but also a recurring theme in Nye's career. Nye's answer to it was firmly: "Not yet," as the United States has consistently demonstrated extraordinary resilience. However, he also warned that America's dominance in the twenty-first century would differ from that of the twentieth century. As Asia and China return to their "rightful place in history," will the "Asian Century" replace the "American Century"? In his book, Nye says, "the greatest danger we face is not that China will surpass us, but that the diffusion of power will produce entropy, or the inability to get anything done." Therefore, Nye believed that the United States and China should manage their competition while collaborating in areas that threaten humanity's existence and the well-being of both nations: climate change, global public health, nuclear non-proliferation, artificial intelligence, trade and economic relations, and cultural exchanges.

¹ This is the foreword to the Chinese Edition of Joseph Nye Jr.'s autobiography *A Life in the American Century*, which has been translated into English and adapted for this collection.

The Embodiment of the American Dream

Nye's life is a perfect embodiment of the American Dream. His ancestors were immigrants from different European countries, from Britain and Ireland to Germany, and represented different denominations of Christianity—Puritanism and Catholicism. They sought opportunities in this “New World” and became a part of the American melting pot. Nye grew up in a rural area of New Jersey, his father a partner in a bond company and his mother a secretary. He received his education at local elementary and secondary schools, then entered Princeton University through his own efforts. He later continued his studies at Oxford University (where he received a Rhodes Scholarship) and Harvard University, studying under renowned scholars such as Henry Kissinger. He co-developed the theory of neoliberal institutionalism in international relations with Robert Keohane—while traditional liberalism views economic interdependence as a tool for achieving peace, they proposed that economic interdependence could also be used as a tool or weapon in confrontations between powers. Though Nye and Keohane argued for a realist perspective when analyzing international relations, starting from the reality that there is no global government and that nations rely on power balances to maintain order. They argued that power is multidimensional and that cooperation via institutions is both possible and rational. Their 1976 book, *Power and Interdependence*, has been reprinted multiple times and remains a standard textbook in teaching international relations to this day.

In addition to teaching at Harvard University, Nye held two government positions. During the Carter administration, he served as Assistant Secretary of State, proposing and vigorously promoting the International Nuclear Fuel Cycle Evaluation program. During his tenure, he advanced policies to prevent nuclear proliferation and was awarded the State Department's Distinguished Service Award. During the Clinton administration, Nye served as Chairman of the National Intelligence Council (NIC) and Assistant Secretary of Defense, launching the “Nye Initiative,” reinforcing the US-Japan alliance, and establishing a power balance in Asia, for which he received the NIC's Distinguished Service Medal and the Department of Defense Distinguished Service Award.

In the 1980s, Japan's growing economic power threatened America's global dominance, reigniting the discussions about America's decline. British historian Paul Kennedy, in his book *The Rise and Fall of the Great Powers*, categorized the United States at the time alongside nations like Spain under Philip II or England during the Edwardian era. To refute this view, Nye wrote *Bound to Lead: The Changing Nature of American Power*. In the book, Nye introduced the concept of “soft power” for the first time and published a paper with the same title in *Foreign Policy* at the same time. This groundbreaking theory divides national power into two dimensions: hard power and soft power. The former encompasses quantifiable resources such as economic scale, military strength, and technological capabilities, while the latter refers to soft influences such as cultural dissemination, value identity, and diplomatic strategies. Nye emphasizes that only by combining the two skillfully to form “smart power” can a nation maximize the effectiveness of its strategies. As his theoretical framework

continued to develop, Nye became widely recognized by the international academic community as the “father of soft power.” In 2004, Nye published *Soft Power: The Means to Success in World Politics*, using empirical analysis to reveal the critical role of cultural appeal and institutional identity in global governance. In 2020, Nye took a different approach in his book *Do Morals Matter?: Presidents and Foreign Policy from FDR to Trump*, using “moral dimensions” as an analytical tool to examine the foreign policies of US presidents from Roosevelt to Trump and provided an innovative perspective for interpreting the evolution of US global strategy and contemporary changes in the international landscape. He continued to develop the soft power theory and expand the ethical dimension of international relations research.

Another of Nye’s major achievements is the establishment of an extensive network. In addition to holding positions in transnational and non-governmental organizations such as the Trilateral Commission and the Aspen Strategy Group, during his tenure as the Dean of Harvard University’s Kennedy School of Government, Nye promoted the establishment of multiple training and exchange programs, particularly a high-level official training program with China. Many current senior officials in the Chinese government have studied at the Kennedy School, which has made a significant contribution to China-US exchanges.

CCG’s Interactions with Professor Nye

I first met Professor Nye in 2010 when I was a senior fellow at the Kennedy School of Government, where he was a professor and former dean. We hit it off immediately and have maintained close communication ever since. Even after the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, we continued to stay in touch online. At the beginning of 2020, we participated as guest speakers in an online seminar on COVID-19 and economic growth organized by the Boao Forum for Asia Academy. In October 2020, we joined an online roundtable discussion hosted by the European think tank “Friends of Europe.” In April 2021, I invited him to participate in the “CCG Global Dialogues,” a video program, as a dialogue guest, to discuss “Power Narratives in a Changing World: Implications for US-China Competition.” In the same year, Professor Nye also contributed a forward-looking article titled “China and the United States: Looking Forward 40 Years” to the book *Consensus or Conflict?: China and Globalization in the 21st Century*, which I co-edited with Alistair Michie.

In 2023, the book I compiled for Nye *Soft Power and Great-Power Competition: Shifting Sands in the Balance of Power Between the United States and China* was published in both Chinese and English. Nye attended the book launch event online and delivered a speech. In October of the same year, Nye visited China to participate in the 8th China Global Think Tank Innovation Forum co-hosted by CCG and the Chinese People’s Association for Friendship with Foreign Countries. In 2024, Nye invited me and Mabel Lu Miao, Secretary-General of CCG, to attend the Aspen Strategy Group’s annual security forum, where we were the only Chinese representatives. The forum featured over 40 dialogue sessions and seminars around themes such as “The

China Challenge,” “Infinity and Beyond: Space and National Security,” “Start Ups to the Rescue: The Next Gen Industrial Base,” and “Flammable World: Who Will Help the World’s Most Vulnerable?” “Democratice Resiliance in the Age of AI.” During the forum, Nye held a book launch event for his autobiography. In his remarks, he noted that China and the United States have extensive opportunities for cooperation in areas such as climate change, pandemic control, and infrastructure development, and can work together to address global challenges. This impressed me deeply.

In my view, Professor Nye is a truly admirable academic giant. He is sharp-minded and far-sighted, always able to penetrate complex international situations and foresee future trends. For example, about ten years before the 9/11 attacks, he warned that the United States was not prepared to respond to such attacks. He is skilled at building networks and has a warm and approachable manner when interacting with others. He has made tremendous efforts to maintain US alliances and bridge the divide between the two major political parties in the US.

Even in his late 80s, Professor Nye remained passionate about academia and maintained a vigorous spirit, continuing to write prolifically. He published one or two insightful and analytically rigorous articles on international politics in authoritative academic platforms or mainstream media almost every month, offering profound insights into the global political landscape for both the academic community and the general public.

Moreover, Professor Nye remained actively engaged on the international political stage. He frequently traveled between the United States and various parts of the world and attended important events at the invitation of hosts. With profound professional expertise and unique insights, he facilitated in-depth discussions on hot issues in international politics, contributing wisdom and strength to addressing global challenges. He was also a media favorite, consistently explaining complex international political phenomena to the public in an accessible manner.

Additionally, Professor Nye served as co-chair of the Aspen Strategy Group. The Aspen Security Forum, hosted by the group, has significant influence in international politics. The forum is held twice a year, in summer and winter, in Aspen and Washington, D.C. It focuses on key issues in national security and foreign policy and attracts hundreds of elite professionals from the US government, strategic circles, think tanks, diplomatic missions, non-governmental organizations, and the media each year. The forum operates under Chatham House Rule, allowing participants to speak freely and engage in candid and in-depth discussions.

Even after leaving government, Professor Nye continued to exert indirect influence on policy through various channels, such as his students (many of whom have become senior leaders), the “trickle-down” effect of his academic works; commentaries published on journals and newspapers; participation in non-governmental organizations; and television appearances; all of which helped to shape and perpetuate the American Century.

When the American Century Meets the Asian Century

Throughout *A Life in the American Century*, Nye tries to answer one question: “Is the American Century over?,” coincidentally the title of his 2015 book, in which he examined potential challengers—Russia, China, the EU, India, and Brazil—and concluded that by 2045, the United States may still be the world’s leading power, describing the challenges faced by the American Century across different periods through examples from his personal life. At the end of the book, Professor Nye concluded that the American Century has not yet ended, but America’s dominant position in the twenty-first century would be fundamentally different from that of the twentieth century, holding a guardedly optimistic view about the country’s future.

On the other side of the world, after shaking off the shackles of colonialism, Asia began to thrive and has seen decades of development. The share of the global economy held by the Four Asian Tigers, China, India, ASEAN, and others has consistently increased. In the eyes of some scholars and politicians, Asia is returning to its rightful place in history, marking the dawn of the “Asian Century.” Meanwhile, the Global South—made up of developing countries worldwide—is also on the rise, seeking to make its voice heard on the global stage.

In Nye’s eyes, Asia’s revival is natural, as the region has the largest population and has historically been the most economically prosperous. However, whether developing countries can achieve a consensus among themselves also remains to be seen. In his 2025 column for *Project Syndicate* titled “What are the BRICS good for?,” Nye wrote that within the BRICS group, Russia, China, and India all vie for leadership, and “the group’s stated intention of avoiding the dollar and clearing more of its members’ bilateral trade in their own currencies has made only limited headway.” To replace the dollar as a global reserve currency, China must back the Renminbi with deep, flexible capital markets and the rule of law, but these conditions are far from being met. Therefore, whether the BRICS countries can become a new fulcrum of world politics remains unknown.

On the future of the American Century, Professor Nye seems more worried about domestic changes and the potential impact of changes on America’s soft power. He believes that “even if its external power remains dominant, a country can lose its internal virtue and attractiveness to others.”² For example, in his view, Trump’s “America First” policy was a betrayal of liberal internationalism by withdrawing from multilateral institutions, disregarding allies, and stoking populism not only weakened America’s soft power but also accelerated the fragmentation of the global order. Professor Nye argued that despite its flaws, the United States is an innovative society that has successfully reinvented and recreated itself many times in the past. Maybe Gen Z will do it again. But he also warned that the United States should be wary of counting too heavily on American exceptionalism.

Professor Nye believed that in the future, the United States should reshape its leadership through cooperation by attracting other countries with its institutions and values while also maintaining its advantage in military and technological fields. He

² Joseph Nye Jr., *A Life in the American Century*, Cambridge: Polity, 2024.

felt that the United States should collaborate with China, the EU, and others on transnational challenges and issues such as climate change, global public health, and artificial intelligence, as these areas can only be addressed through cooperation. Although Nye firmly believed that the US-led liberal international order could provide a “better” future for the world and I am sure that if he had engaged in more in-depth exchanges with the Global South, their voices would have undoubtedly provided him with further inspiration.

China-US Relations: Competition and Cooperation

As the world’s largest developing country and the largest developed country, the largest emerging power and the established power, representatives of the Global South and North, and representing the two largest carbon emitters globally, there is no doubt that the relationship between China and the United States has become the most important bilateral one of the twenty-first century.

Nye argued that China is an impressive peer competitor with great strengths but also weaknesses. In assessing the overall balance of power, Nye notes that the United States has at least five long-term advantages. First, geography. The United States is surrounded by two oceans and two friendly neighbors, while China shares borders with fourteen other countries, several of which it is engaged in territorial disputes with. Second, the United States has a strong energy advantage, whereas China depends on energy imports. Third, the United States derives power from its large transnational financial institutions and the international role of the dollar. A credible reserve currency depends on it being freely convertible, building deep capital markets, and the rule of law, which China lacks. The United States also has a relative demographic advantage as the only major developed country that is currently projected to hold its place (third) in the global population ranking. Seven of the world’s fifteen largest economies will see their workforces shrink over the next decade, but the US workforce is expected to grow; comparatively, China’s workforce peaked in 2014. Finally, America has been at the forefront in key technologies (bio, nano, and information). China, of course, is investing heavily in research and development and scores well in the numbers of patents, but by its own measures its research universities still rank behind American ones.³

Nye has also argued that China is a potential challenger to the American Century but not an existential threat to the United States unless the United States makes it one by blundering into a major war. Clearly, the United States’ China policy has transitioned from “engagement and enlargement” into a “great power rivalry,” with both sides set to engage in intense competition across technologies ranging from quantum computing to AI, economic issues such as supply chain restructuring and global rule-making, military affairs, and values. However, this does not preclude the possibility of cooperation. In 2024, while the former State Secretary Blinken was visiting China,

³ Joseph Nye Jr., *A Life in the American Century*, Cambridge: Polity, 2024.

Professor Nye led a delegation from the Aspen Strategy Group to China for a Track-II diplomatic dialogue with the Party School of the CPC Central Committee. In an article titled “US-China Cooperation Remains Possible” written for *Project Syndicate*, Nye noted that during the dialogue, both sides identified seven areas for potential cooperation: climate change, global public health, nuclear weapons, artificial intelligence (especially in military applications), certain areas of trade, subsidies, and overcapacity, and cultural exchanges.

Nye believed that a war between the United States and China was entirely possible, with the most likely trigger being Taiwan, or miscalculations or provocations by third parties (such as the Philippines or North Korea), which could also spark regional conflicts. In his article “How to Prevent a War over Taiwan,” Nye emphasized that the United States should clearly commit to the “One China” policy, reminding Taiwanese leaders that any *de jure* declaration of independence would be a provocative act and is unacceptable, and to avoid crossing China’s red lines; but at the same time, Taiwan should maintain its self-defense capabilities and ensure that military resources deployed by the United States in Japan, Australia, and the Philippines could reach Taiwan within a week. Nye referred to this as “double deterrence,” which is meant to “extend the status quo indefinitely.”

This year, Trump was elected as president again, with “uncertainty” remaining the hallmark of his term, which he uses as a tactic, especially in US-China relations. Before taking office, Trump publicly stated that China and the United States can cooperate to solve all the problems in the world. However, shortly after assuming office, he announced an additional 10% tariff on Chinese imports to the United States on top of existing tariffs and soon launched another tariff war. But this leaves people wondering—where will US-China relations head in the future?

Nye once said that Trump has “low situational intelligence” in international affairs, and his excessive narcissism limits his emotional intelligence. Trump is skilled at leveraging populism, protectionism, and nationalism to gain attention, and his policies challenge the fundamental premises of American foreign policy and the American Century. His choice of Marco Rubio as Secretary of State and Michael Waltz as National Security Advisor, are both well-known “hawkish” figures who view China as a major threat that requires a strong response. In my view, this approach is more reflective of Trump’s negotiation strategy, which involves adopting a tough stance initially to ultimately achieve outcomes that align with his interests. I believe that if both China and the United States focus their efforts on economic and trade negotiations, cooperation is entirely possible. This would also help to manage competition between China and the United States, avoid miscalculations, and prevent self-fulfilling threats.

A Life in the American Century is a record of Professor Nye’s thoughts and practices, filled with both heartfelt details and candid reflections on decision-making processes. It also illustrates the evolution of American foreign policy over the past half century and is helpful in understanding its underlying logic, which will ultimately help us in making choices and shaping the future we desire.

The Dawn of the Asian Century⁴

With the rise of China and increased confidence among many developing Asian nations, a rejuvenation of Asia is leading towards an “Asian Century”, according to Kishore Mahbubani, renowned Singaporean diplomat and scholar, who sees this shift as beneficial for world as a whole.

As the momentum of an Asian rejuvenation grows, discussions about whether the twenty-first century will be the Asian Century are becoming more and more heated. When talking about “Asian rejuvenation” and an “Asian century,” one cannot fail to mention the Singaporean diplomat and public intellectual Kishore Mahbubani. He was one of the first scholars to analyze and discuss Asian rejuvenation and has been tirelessly promoting the idea that “the twenty-first century will be the Asian Century” for decades.

While there are countless grand narratives about the Asian rejuvenation and the Asian Century, Kishore Mahbubani’s memoir *Living the Asian Century* takes a different approach. It delves into the details of his personal life, using the small to illustrate the large, reflecting how the grand narrative of Asia’s fight for independence, economic development, and the right for their voice to be heard in international arenas after the Second World War have transformed the lives and thinking of Asian peoples once ruled by Western colonizers, and how Mahbubani himself has gradually become a confident diplomat and public intellectual capable of navigating international negotiations for his motherland’s interests on an international level.

Kishore Mahbubani’s identity, personal growth, and achievements make him one of the best spokespeople for Asian rejuvenation. He is an Indian-Singaporean whose parents fled to Singapore due to the riots and ethnic massacres triggered by the British-led Partition of India and Pakistan. Kishore Mahbubani was born in Singapore in 1948 and grew up in a poor neighborhood where Hindu, Muslim, and Chinese cultures coexisted and blended. At that time, Singapore was still under British colonial rule, and the educational curriculum was still aimed at cultivating pro-British “imperial subjects.” Kishore Mahbubani loved reading and thinking, and majored in philosophy during his university years. This led him to reflect on the education he had received and to view the world through a dialectical lens. He received his undergraduate education at the National University of Singapore, pursued a master’s degree in Canada and was awarded an honorary doctorate, later also becoming a visiting scholar at Harvard University. His diverse educational background shaped his multilateralist perspective and ideology, which he fully utilized in his diplomatic career, which spanned 33 years, including two terms as president of the United Nations Security Council, and enabled him to witness and participate in countless diplomatic negotiations. Meanwhile, the ideas and principles of Singapore’s founders also had a profound influence on him, helping him develop his own geopolitical theory. After retiring, he continued to be involved in academia and became a globally renowned

⁴ This is the foreword of the Chinese Edition of Kishore Mahbubani’s autobiography *Living the Asian Century* and adapted for this collection.

expert on Asian issues, earning the title of “the muse of the Asian Century.” His professional achievements have granted him significant influence in both the East and West. Kishore Mahbubani has been advocating the concepts of Asian rejuvenation and an Asian century for some time and has published numerous monographs on the subject.

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I have known Kishore Mahbubani for nearly 20 years, and we have discussed issues and exchanged views on numerous occasions, both publicly and privately, including at events like the World Economic Forum in Davos and the Boao Forum for Asia. He has always warmly invited me to attend the launches of his new books. We have also worked together. In May 2019, we participated in the globally renowned Munk Debates, held in Toronto, Canada, where we debated whether China poses a threat to the liberal international order. Our opponents were H. R. McMaster, a former National Security Advisor to President Trump and a hawkish figure on China, and Michael Pillsbury, Director of the China Centre at the Hudson Institute, who represented the mainstream Western view that “China poses a threat to liberal international order.” The debate was held in a Western country, and the atmosphere was unfriendly to those in favor of China. That evening, Kishore and I worked seamlessly, refuting the opposing side’s misleading narratives with reason, evidence, and restraint. The vote by the 3,000-member audience at the end of the debate showed that we had won by directly addressing Western skepticism during the debate and providing a solid rebuttal.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, we held multiple online exchanges, and in 2021, CCG was invited to translate Kishore’s new book *Has China Won?*, a globally best-selling political commentary, into Chinese. Together with CITIC Press, we organized a launch event and seminar that included a video conference with Kishore to discuss the “the question of the century”—how will US-China relations evolve? In the book, Kishore poses a thought-provoking question: faced with global challenges such as the COVID-19 pandemic, global recovery, and climate change, the question we should ask is not whether China or the United States has won, but whether humanity has won. The book has received widespread acclaim from academics, publishers, and general readers. Later, we also organized a special dialogue session on the book, titled “China, Globalization, and a Multipolar World in the Post-Pandemic Era,” which was part of the CCG Global Dialogue series. During the dialogue, Kishore Mahbubani reiterated that there is no fundamental core conflict of interest between China and the United States. The two countries would be better off allocating resources to improving the well-being of their own people and cooperating on common challenges like climate change, rather than engaging in geopolitical competition, which harms the interests of both countries and the world as a whole. The transcript of this dialogue has been included in the book *CCG Global Dialogues: Understanding Globalization, Global Gaps, and Power Shifts in the 21st Century*, published by the renowned global publisher Palgrave Macmillan.

In the same year, Kishore Mahbubani also contributed an article titled “Globalization Is Dead! Long Live Globalization!” to one of CCG’s English publications, *Consensus or Conflict?*, co-edited by Mabel Lu Miao and me. The Russia-Ukraine war broke out shortly after the book was released, clearly indicating that building global consensus is a long and arduous journey.

In 2022, CCG and Kishore Mahbubani jointly released the English edition of *The Asian 21st Century* and held a seminar. This book was part of the English series “China and Globalization,” which is co-edited by Mabel Lu Miao and me, and includes other books such as *Consensus or Conflict?*, *Perspectives from Ambassadors to China* (Volumes 1 and 2), *Transition and Opportunity*, *The Ebb and Flow of Globalization*, Professor Joseph S. Nye Jr.’s work *Soft Power and Great-Power Competition*, *Enhancing Global Governance in a Fragmented World*, and *Global Development and Cooperation with China: New Ideas, Policies and Initiatives for a Changing World*. All these books are available on the Springer Nature website.

The book *The Asian 21st Century* has garnered widespread attention from the international community, with over 4 million downloads since its launch on December 30, 2021. The global president of Springer Nature, the book’s publisher, has said that the downloads are nearly a hundred times higher than the average for academic publications. At the seminar we organized in January 2022 for this book, which was themed “The Rise of Asia and Its Implications for an Increasingly Multipolar World,” two renowned scholars in the field of Asian studies—Kent E. Calder, Deputy Dean of the School of Advanced International Studies (SAIS) at Johns Hopkins University and Director of the Edwin O. Reischauer Center for East Asian Studies, and Kerry Brown, Director of the Lau China Institute at King’s College London, both praised the book, agreeing that it accurately describes the major transformations currently unfolding in the world and holds an important message for the West. With the considerable attention the book received around the world, Kishore held another seminar in Singapore that welcomed guests including Professor Koh Cheng Hsing, Dean of the Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy at the National University of Singapore, and Chan Heng Chee, Ambassador-at-Large of Singapore’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs. Former Chinese Ambassador to Singapore Sun Haiyan also praised the book’s perspectives and the author’s influence.

In 2023, the simplified Chinese edition of *The Asian 21st Century* was published by CITIC Press, which was also followed by a book launch at CCG’s Beijing headquarters, where Kishore delivered a speech that received widespread coverage and attention. The same year, the traditional Chinese edition was published by Joint Publishing (Hong Kong).

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As a diplomat representing a small country, Kishore deeply understands and highly values the significance of multilateralism, which China has consistently advocated for in global governance. At the Boao Forum for Asia in early 2025, Kishore and I engaged in a high-level dialogue on the future of multilateralism. Kishore believes that Western leadership of global affairs is drawing to a close and that the world has

entered a “3M” period, one of multipolarity, multilateralism, and multiculturalism. However, the West is finding it difficult to accept this reality and trying to use existing institutions and power bases to maintain its dominance. Kishore believes that the United Nations should reflect the voices of the entire world, but the West, which accounts for only 12% of the global population, holds 60% of the seats on the UN Security Council. Clearly, the United Nations should be reformed to fully and adequately reflect the voices of diverse groups and societies.

Kishore pointed out that over the past few decades, Asia has made significant contributions to maintaining peace, preventing wars, and driving global economic growth. The Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) and its Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) initiative provide an excellent example of an institutional platform for effective collaboration in regions with high levels of diversity. Therefore, he suggests that existing regional and sub-regional agreements and arrangements in Asia be further integrated, with Asian countries or organizations continuing to work together to make the twenty-first century a truly Asian Century, which is similar in spirit to the “Asian Union” that I have long advocated. In the face of the rising tide of anti-globalization and increasing fragmentation in the world, regional integration has become an important means of fostering multilateral cooperation, which is conducive to global development. Against a backdrop of the Asian rejuvenation, an Asian Union could be established based on an “ASEAN+3” framework along with efforts to advance Asia-Pacific regional integration to mitigate geopolitical tensions in the Asia-Pacific region, which would help maintain regional peace, stability, and prosperity. In my book *China and Globalization in the 21st Century*, published by CITIC Press, I argue that the influence of Confucian culture on East Asian countries have created a cultural consensus of principle that includes “harmony without uniformity,” “harmony and unity of heaven and humanity,” and “taking the perspective of the other,” which can help foster closer economic cooperation while acknowledging and preserving the diversity of economic, cultural, and historical-political identities of the peoples in the region.

Today, a number of regional economic agreements have been signed in the Asia-Pacific region, including the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP), RCEP, and ASEAN “10+N,” which to some extent demonstrates the vitality of Asia’s economy and the strong willingness of all parties to cooperate. However, the large number of trade agreements has also led to “fragmentation,” which is detrimental to regional stability and development. Therefore, promoting the unification of standards between free trade zones, creating a common market with unified standards, and establishing a Free Trade Area of the Asia-Pacific (FTAAP) that would cover the entire Asia-Pacific region are issues that need to be addressed in the future. According to the research by CCG, an FTAAP can be achieved in two ways: first, by merging the CPTPP and RCEP; or second, by forming an “umbrella agreement” that incorporates the CPTPP and RCEP. The FTAAP could establish an intermediate standard that addresses tariff reductions, the opening up of service sectors, and intellectual property rules, thereby establishing a multi-tiered free trade system across the Asia-Pacific region. This would facilitate a process of

Asian integration would be significant in the current context of global uncertainty and the growing scarcity of global public goods.

In the face of the current global trend toward division, Kishore Mahbubani also urges Europe and the United States to engage in more economic cooperation with Asia, stating that “the best way to make America great again is to make the whole world great.”

* * *

Living the Asian Century is Kishore Mahbubani’s memoir, in which he reveals the details of his journey from poverty to becoming an academic and diplomat, candidly retelling the ups and downs of his life and changes in his thinking, without shying away from the criticism of others. He opens up and speaks frankly about his life, recalling his interactions with Singaporean leaders and diplomats from other countries, linking his own experiences to a wider narrative, making history vivid, tangible, and full of warmth. In the book, he expresses his gratitude for Singapore’s success and Asia’s development, as it is this broader historical context that has nurtured a figure as legendary and influential as Kishore Mahbubani. CCG was honored to have been invited to translate this book into Chinese and coordinate the distribution of the simplified Chinese edition through the World Affairs Press, which is affiliated with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

We extend our gratitude to all those who support the publication of this book, which we believe will offer a unique perspective for those interested in diplomatic affairs and the rejuvenation of Asia, thereby deepening their multi-layered and multi-angled understanding of these fields.

The Last Revelation from a Master of Realism⁵

Predicting the trajectory of international relations is fraught because of the massive number of variables both public and obscured, in his book, Kissinger tackles the variable of leadership and the role it has to play in determining the course of history as the world faces complex challenges and changes.

Observing a Century of Change Through a Single Life

What kind of leaders do we need indeed? This weighty question is precisely what Dr. Henry Kissinger sought to address in this book.

Following *On China* and *World Order*, *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy* concludes Kissinger's "Trilogy" of historical reflections and future insights. The English edition was published in May 2022, by which time the COVID-19 pandemic had raged for two years; the Russia-Ukraine war had erupted three months prior; ChatGPT's public release was half a year away; Dr. Kissinger's last visit to China was still a year and two months in the future, and his sudden passing was a year and a half away.

In this sense, *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy* is of historical significance, representing the intellectual legacy the author left at a critical historical juncture. Observing the unprecedented great transformations that occurred over the course of a century through a single person's life has inherent historical value. In the future, many people—whether politicians, scholars, businesspeople, or ordinary readers—will inevitably turn to the work of this wise man for clues to understand the present and pierce the fog that continues to obscure the future, just as people in 2023 sought clues as to the trajectory of major powers relationships from his final visit to China.

Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy is a fascinating work, imbued with Kissinger's distinctive style. Kissinger wrote extensively throughout his life. His early works, such as *Nuclear Weapons and Foreign Policy* and *The Necessity of Choice: The Prospects for American Foreign Policy*, are heavily academic. As he entered politics and experienced several major historical turning points, Kissinger gradually developed his unique narrative style. His later works interweave erudite academic theories and concepts with abundant personal experiences and reflections from pivotal historical moments. Thus, Kissinger's writings often balance grandeur with minute details, intertwining narrative and commentary, making them highly readable.

Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy continues the style of Kissinger's later works, but by changing the subject of the narrative, it becomes even more grabbing. In this book, Kissinger attempts for the first time—and perhaps the only time—to adopt a concise biographical approach to summarize the political careers of six national

⁵ This is a reading guide originally published in Chinese for Kissinger's work *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy* and adapted for this collection.

leaders with whom he has had multiple interactions since World War II and in some cases even developed deep friendships. Kissinger relays to readers that outstanding leaders possess certain inherent abilities and qualities that enable them to penetrate the deep structural turmoil of society and influence the future development of human civilization.

Kissinger's Dissatisfaction and Anxiety

It should be noted that Kissinger does not use a heroic narrative to prove the validity of his theories. While the six leaders he chooses all possess the will to endure hardships and persevere, their lives are not entirely success stories. In the case of Anwar Sadat, he was assassinated for promoting a policy of peace policy with Israel; Richard Nixon resigned in disgrace due to the Watergate scandal; Margaret Thatcher's neoliberal economic policies remain controversial to this day; and Konrad Adenauer, Charles de Gaulle, and Lee Kuan Yew also had their share of controversies. Kissinger deliberately downplays these aspects. What he sought to highlight in the book was the relationship between changing historical contexts and the leaders themselves. In his view, following the end of World War II, the model of national political governance shifted from "aristocratic rule" to "elite governance." The six politicians who rose to prominence after the Second World War were largely unattached to the traditional ruling class. Most of them came from middle class families and entered politics at a time when the pre-war aristocratic political system had been dismantled, enabling them to ascend the political ladder, retaining the aristocratic moral ethos of the past while also embodying the pragmatic behavioral patterns characteristic of the middle class. Kissinger sought to illustrate that, regardless of the success or failure of their governance, the political character of these leaders was universal and enduring.

Kissinger analyzed the leadership style of these six leaders through the dimensions of analytical ability, strategy, courage, and character, seemingly aiming to establish a framework for analysis. However, this is merely superficial. He seemed more concerned with establishing a reference point for readers to draw upon in the future. In the conclusion, he quoted Machiavelli's notion that prolonged peace leads to societal complacency, which in turn causes a decline in leadership. Comparing this to the present, Kissinger stated: "The criteria used to judge leaders throughout history have remained unchanged: whether they can transcend their environment through foresight and dedication."

It is evident that Kissinger harbored dissatisfaction and anxiety regarding the leadership of political figures in the post-Cold War era. He hinted at the potential for leadership decline in times of peace and summarized the essential characteristics of leadership. From this perspective, *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy* is not an objective evaluation of these six leaders but a work strongly influenced by the author's subjective intentions, choosing six individuals of the past but clearly focusing on the present.

As a diplomat and statesman, one of Kissinger's greatest achievements was promoting the development of China-US relations—this was also the major power relationship that most concerned him throughout his life, as reflected in his over 100 visits to China. Even at the age of 100 and until his passing, he continued to visit China and dedicated himself to the improvement of bilateral relations. China-US relations are also a focal point of attention across all sectors and levels of society. CCG has always remained in regular communication and often collaborated with Kissinger, serving as a bridge for him to engage with individuals concerned about China-US relations. On June 28, 2011, the 2005 Committee of the Western Returned Scholars Association, an association that Henry Huiyao Wang, President of CCG, has been a member since its launch, invited Dr. Kissinger to attend a breakfast meeting held at the Beijing International Club. He engaged in discussions with Chinese scholars that returned to China on topics such as China-US exchanges, trade relations, the development of social diversity, and the growth of China's middle class. On November 21–22, 2019, Dr. Wang and Dr. Kissinger attended the 2019 New Economy Forum co-hosted by the China Center for International Economic Exchanges and Bloomberg, which brought together over 500 government officials, corporate executives, innovators, and experts from around the world to discuss solutions to the major challenges facing the world today and explore responses to current global issues. Kissinger repeatedly emphasized the importance of avoiding open conflict between the United States and China, which is undoubtedly of great value.

As a scholar and sage, Kissinger possessed far-reaching strategic vision and foresight. Before his passing, he co-authored an article with Harvard Professor Graham Allison—with whom I previously worked at the Harvard Kennedy School of Government—titled “The Path to AI Arms Control,” warning that artificial intelligence could pose unprecedented threats, some of which may be even more terrifying than those posed by traditional weapons. He argued that global restrictions should be established before artificial intelligence becomes fully integrated into national security, and urged the United States and China, the two leading AI research and development countries, to establish a working group as soon as possible to assess the development and impact of AI. This article was published prior to the 2023 APEC meeting in San Francisco. On November 15th of the same year, following the meeting between the leaders of China and the United States, Foreign Minister Wang Yi informed the media that both sides had agreed to establish an intergovernmental dialogue mechanism on AI.

Whether in public office or as a scholar and sage, Henry Kissinger has always been known as a master of realism. His political identity and life experiences have to some extent shaped his political stance, and his extensive research, particularly his deep understanding of European diplomatic history, has led him to highly value the “balance of power.” The book *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy* continues to carry his realist methodological approach to international relations, arguing that the qualities, capabilities, and courage of leaders can to some extent serve as a counterbalance to historical development, preventing human civilization from plunging into the abyss. The creation of *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy* seems to be an attempt to prove this point.

Are Politicians True Colors Applicable Everywhere?

Kissinger's outstanding diplomatic and administrative career has given him a certain degree of diplomatic flexibility. In his book, he carefully, even cunningly, avoided commenting on certain controversial policies of the six leaders he chose. Regarding de Gaulle, he did not mention the objective impact of France's withdrawal from Algeria on the African colonial system; regarding Nixon, he did not mention the impact of the Watergate scandal on the American political system; regarding Lee Kuan Yew, he did not mention the negative implications of extremely pragmatic policies for decision-making in small countries.

In Kissinger's analysis, while these leaders were indeed realists, their ideals often determined the pragmatism of their actions. They harbored grand ambitions to govern their countries and bring peace to the world, and Kissinger did not hesitate to lavish praise on them for this. However, he also sought to downplay the Machiavellian aspects of their personalities. This also makes the characters in the book appear more noble and upright—de Gaulle is at most a bit aloof and unsociable, while Lee Kuan Yew is simply outspoken in his manner of speaking. As we know, politics does not always shape people in such a way.

Beyond implying Kissinger's characteristic caution and diplomacy, the book also conveys a sense of distance between the author and the figures in the book. While his observations of the six statesmen are richly layered, they are not always accurate. Despite having had close contact with all six leaders, the temporal and cultural gaps remain evident. Kissinger's description of Nixon is notably clear and detailed. Adenauer, born in 1876, and Charles de Gaulle, born in 1890, are significantly older than him and have different historical perspectives compared with Kissinger. The author observes them from a position of admiration, which inevitably feels somewhat superficial. For Sadat and Lee Kuan Yew, cultural differences lead the author to understand them more through their personalities and behavior—rather than strategic thinking—which undoubtedly adds to the complexity of understanding these figures. At their core, leaders may be very simple individuals, but in decision-making, they sometimes depend on rational choices and at other times on instinctive reactions. When writing *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy*, the author may have overemphasized the value of leadership.

However, overall, Kissinger highlights the homogeneity of leadership among these six individuals. Given his extensive international experience, Kissinger could have chosen any more contemporary leaders as subjects for his narrative. But the obvious homogeneity among these six individuals ensures that Kissinger's understanding and interpretation of leadership will be passed on to future generations. Just as MacArthur repeatedly emphasized "duty, honor, and country" in his farewell speech at West Point to highlight the essence of a soldier, Kissinger also shows his understanding of the role of a statesman over the past century in his final work, using an apocalyptic tone to articulate the qualities of "courage, perseverance, and strategy," hoping to instill the idea in future generations that these are universal truths applicable to all.

China and Europe: Learning from the Past to Understand the Present and Future⁶

The mirror of history provides invaluable lessons for us if we only look into it. Kerry Brown's research into 800 years of European views on China gives us a unique perspective on this important relationship and how to improve it going forward.

Today's world is experiencing intense geopolitical competition with portents of a new Cold War and the outbreak of regional conflicts. Professor Kerry Brown's book *China Through European Eyes: 800 Years of Cultural and Intellectual Encounter* examines the writings of European historical figures on China over the past eight centuries, offering both an intriguing historical perspective and a re-assessment of modern China. Vitally, it helps readers around the world to better understand the historical roots of relations between Europe and China.

Professor Brown argues that Europeans and Americans tend to marginalize China, which makes those in the West unaccustomed to seeing a rising China as a major power and an equal. Secondly, Europeans are stuck in their own beliefs and lack a basic understanding of Chinese values, either dismissing them as unimportant or simply refusing to learn about them. Sometimes, they even casually label Chinese values as problematic, in conflict with Western values, and a threat to the West.

Professor Brown believes that Chinese values are a "hybrid" as China's culture and history have been influenced by a wide range of ethical, philosophical, and religious perspectives, from Confucianism to Daoism as well as contemporary belief systems, which have created a highly flexible worldview that is difficult to define succinctly. For this reason, Professor Brown explores a range of European perspectives to help Western readers better understand Chinese history and culture, increase their knowledge base, and promote dialogue and mutual understanding. This was the primary motivation for Professor Brown in compiling this book.

In this era of uncertainty, it is important that two civilizations that could have avoided misunderstanding in the first place should commit to promoting mutual exchange in order to gain a clearer understanding of each other. Professor Brown's work encourages Europeans to gain a new understanding of China and has gone much further than many "China experts" in the West by exploring the historical depths of the past eight centuries and practical exchanges between Europe and China to seek answers to today's pressing questions.

I have known Professor Brown for many years. His most recent visit to CCG was in 2019 to participate in a symposium on China-US-Europe relations and global governance co-hosted by CCG and the Royal Institute of International Affairs. Professor Brown graduated from the world-renowned University of Cambridge and is a prominent expert in China studies in the UK. He currently serves as the director of the Lau China Institute at King's College London. He first came to China in 1994

⁶ This is the foreword of the Chinese edition of Kerry Brown's edited book *China Through European Eyes: 800 Years of Cultural and Intellectual Encounter*, co-authored by Henry Huiyao Wang and Mabel Lu Miao, and adapted for this collection.

and later served as first secretary at the British Embassy there, interacting with various sectors of Chinese society and developing a comprehensive, objective, and multi-dimensional understanding of China. Since 2006, he has authored over twenty works on China, including *A Tale of Five Chinese Cities*, and established himself as an internationally influential China expert who is both knowledgeable about and friendly toward China.

His latest research work, *China Through European Eyes*, which was translated into Chinese by the Center for China and Globalization, is divided into five sections, compiling excerpts from the writings of sixteen prominent European figures on China, beginning in the thirteenth century when Marco Polo visited China and proceeding to the mid-twentieth century and the Cultural Revolution.

The first section, titled “Origins,” begins with descriptions of China by Marco Polo, Samuel Purchas, and Matteo Ricci; the second section continues with the writings of three important European Enlightenment thinkers—Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz, Voltaire, and Montesquieu—on China; the third section recounts John Barrow’s impressions of China during his visit with the Macartney Embassy, Georg Hegel and Karl Marx’s perspectives and sympathies toward feudal China, as well as Evariste Régis Huc’s exploration of China’s frontiers; the fourth part delves deeper with research by Max Weber, Bertrand Russell, and Carl Gustav Jung on Chinese beliefs, the China question, and Chinese wisdom; finally, the fifth part closes with observations from Simone de Beauvoir, Julia Kristeva, and Roland Barthes on China under Mao Zedong.

These sixteen authors have been extremely influential in Western thinking. While eight of them visited China in person, the other eight—Samuel Purchas, Leibniz, Voltaire, Montesquieu, Hegel, Marx, Max Weber, and Carl Gustav Jung—researched a wide range of literature on China. In explaining why he chose these authors, Professor Brown said he felt Marco Polo provided an excellent starting point for outlining how outsiders have viewed China over the past eight centuries, while Matteo Ricci’s work is significant because it demonstrates that it is entirely feasible, though extremely challenging, to engage deeply with the Chinese way of thinking and its culture while maintaining a European worldview and perspective. He continues, saying that Leibniz keenly identified commonalities in Chinese traditions and European religion and philosophy, while Voltaire described China as tolerant and inclusive. John Barrow’s account of the Macartney Embassy to China provides European views at the beginning of “the century of humiliation,” which remains a painful memory in the minds of the Chinese people. Hegel’s ideas deeply influenced a young Karl Marx and indirectly influenced China’s journey toward modernization and the ultimate choice to pursue communism. Evariste Régis Huc’s travelogue provides insight into the many admirable aspects of the Chinese people, their way of life, and their traditions from a European perspective. Weber dedicated himself to exploring the beliefs of the Chinese people, while Bertrand Russell held the Chinese people and their spirit in the highest regard, seeing the East and West as equals and emphasizing the view that the East should not be viewed as less than the West. Carl Jung unwittingly contributed to understanding the “mysterious” and “exotic” side of “Eastern

wisdom,” while Simone de Beauvoir, who visited China during the Cultural Revolution, wrote about seeing a China that had been liberated from exploitative socioeconomic class relations. Finally, Kristeva notes how the People’s Republic of China officially recognized the rights of Chinese women in 1950.

Professor Brown deeply believes that collecting and studying the views of these important thinkers on China can help readers in the West take China seriously, and he states at the end of the book’s preface that, *“China’s ‘difference’ is often seen as a triggering statement—an attempt to postulate some other which can then become the object of idealism or condemnation. But the writers in this work all show very different ways of dealing with China realistically, empirically, with critical enquiry. None adopt the airy luxury of observing China from nowhere—but locate themselves either in a European or a rational location and launch their enquiry from there. What unites them in the urgent need to take this place, with its complex traditions and world view, seriously—and to be puzzled and in some ways unsettled by how best to think about China accurately and honestly. In an era vexed by Sinophobes and Sinophiles, panda huggers and dragon slayers, putting together the views expressed here by such different, but distinct and important thinkers, perhaps offers an antidote to jumping to conclusions too quickly.”*

I believe this book has a great significance in promoting better understanding of global diversity, greater inclusiveness of different civilizations—especially China—as well as dialogue and mutual understanding between China and Europe. After finishing the book, I truly feel that it has achieved Professor Brown’s goal as the views and perspectives on China from prominent European figures can be more persuasive and inspire those in the West to be more rational when looking at China and Chinese civilization and become more inclusive in their ideological views.

However, this book is also significant for readers in China and other parts of the world, deepening their understanding of current relations between China and Europe, which is very unique and in more recent times has become a close, practical connection. In 2021, China was the EU’s largest trading partner, while the EU was China’s second-largest trading partner. In the same year, 15,000 freight trains traversed the Eurasian continent between China and Europe, while 200,000 Chinese students braved the risk of COVID-19 to begin their studies in European countries.

In 2021, China and Europe were two giants at opposite ends of the Eurasian continent, ranking as the world’s second and third largest economies with a combined population that accounted for a quarter of the global total. Both of these giants have proud histories and philosophical traditions that have endured to the present day. Their geographic distance means that they have virtually no territorial disputes and have regularly worked together to address the world’s challenges. One of the most significant achievements of this cooperation in the twenty-first century was the 2015 United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, the Paris Agreement, initiated by the European Union and facilitated by China. In terms of global governance, both advocate multilateralism, support free trade, and have made significant contributions to human civilization. They should join hands, seek common ground despite their differences, and work together to address common challenges to humanity.

On globalization, the vibrant and dynamic Europe that emerged in the 1990s and the early 2000s was a fine example of globalization. As an economic and political alliance uniting most European nations, the EU swiftly emerged as one of the most important players in the global order. With the evolution of new global power structures, a new era of “three-way dynamics” emerged, with the United States, the EU, and China as the main players. China and Europe share significant common interests, while the EU and the UN Security Council serve as an important balancing force in international relations, which is essential to peaceful and sustainable globalization.

However, despite efforts to exercise stability and restraint in relations with China, the EU Commission’s March 2019 report *EU-China Strategic Outlook* defined China as both a partner for cooperation and negotiation and an economic competitor, as well as a systemic rival.

With the global spread of COVID-19 in 2020 and the outbreak of the Russia-Ukraine war in February 2022, China’s role as a partner faded in the eyes of European leaders and media, and increasingly resembles that of a competitor and adversary—a trend we must collectively study and avoid.

Constrained by subject matter and the overall environment, researching the current phase of Chinese political history poses significant challenges for many Western political scientists, both in terms of the time frame as well as the theoretical tools at their disposal. Their research can explain many Chinese political phenomena in isolation, but they lack an overall framework, if it exists at all, and merely follow the historical inertia of “Orientalism,” which was strongly criticized by Edward Said for fitting Eastern phenomena into Western theories, using one’s own ideas to explain others’ behavior.

It is difficult to say whether Professor Kerry Brown’s research has been influenced by this deeply ingrained approach, but he is at least aware of its existence. He has traveled extensively in China, accumulating a wealth of experience as a teacher, diplomat, businessman, and scholar. These experiences, combined with his proficiency in Chinese, have undoubtedly provided him with the advantage of viewing contemporary Chinese politics from a broader and deeper perspective. In recent years, he has increasingly explored China’s history and cultural traditions, as well as their influence on contemporary Chinese politics, enriching and diversifying his observations. A prime example of this is his opposition to using the Western term “faction” to distinguish between high-level political groups in China. He also recognizes the complex components of Chinese political philosophy, which incorporates both the Marxist origins of the ruling party and the traditions inherited from Confucianism, Taoism, and Buddhism that have existed in China for thousands of years.

One of the major features of this work is Professor Brown’s use of a methodology that views the dynamic relations between China and Europe through a historical lens, which explains aspects of modern Sino-European relations by referencing historical interactions between China and Europe.

The historical exchanges between these great civilizations have played an important role in the history of human civilization. Marx believed that Chinese gunpowder helped the Western bourgeoisie ascend to the historical stage, while Voltaire used his own imagined idealized concept of China to enlighten the French people on the eve

of the French Revolution. Their views reflected positive aspects of Europe's perception of China, while negative aspects were articulated by figures like Montesquieu, showing two opposing sides of Europe's perception of China.

In January 2022, Professor Brown described the past 800 years of Sino-European exchanges in the following way: *"The pattern that you get over that 800 years is broadly two narratives, two stories. On the one hand, to idealize China, and the other to be fearful and demonize it. Leibniz and Voltaire, I suppose represent idolization. They regarded China with its Confucian meritocratic system as a valid alternative to what Europeans were doing at the time in the enlightenment. That has continued down to the present day. The other hand, figures like Montesquieu wrote of China as being an oriental despotic place that we shouldn't copy. Form the narratives that we have available, I don't see that fundamental structure has changed, at least in Europe, and it seems to be true in America and Australia too."*

In this sense, Professor Brown's review and commentary on nearly 800 years of historical documents on Sino-European relations serves to establish a comprehensive framework for Europe to realize that China is not an "Eastern autocratic state" and gaining a proper understanding of history to correct this misperception. Professor Brown himself said in an interview that for Europe and the United States, one of the most urgent tasks today is to address the lack of basic knowledge about Chinese traditional culture, so that they at least know who they are trying to collaborate with, rather than acting on hypothetical assumptions.

Today, criticism of China in Europe is evolving in a politically correct direction and Professor Brown is considered to be a scholar who speaks candidly. He never hesitates to say that what Europe and China need today is cooperation and coexistence. In a recent conversation he said that, *"That there was even a small moderate middle space, even as these arguments intensified for Britain, Europe and the US, in particular, which was important for the very simple reason that for all the legitimate concerns about the places where China increasingly didn't align to Western interests and expectations, and in some of the most important areas, there was plenty to work together on. Of these, areas concerning climate change, sustainability, public health and economic recovery after the pandemic were at the front. In all of these, China figured as a largely collaborative partner—even if this was more about potential than actuality."*

With his extensive experience, boundless energy, and outspoken personality, Professor Brown has become a highly sought-after expert on China among global media outlets. As stated in the preface to his book *A Tale of Five Chinese Cities*, he has been interviewed by "every major media outlet in the world" and participated in countless forums, summits, and academic discussions on China. I first met Professor Brown at an international conference years ago and, with CCG's emphasis on mutual understanding and international cooperation to prevent conflict, our positions aligned perfectly. Furthermore, CCG's role as an international platform for exchange means that Professor Brown's collaboration with CCG has even closer. In recent years, he has participated in numerous online and in-person dialogues organized by CCG, engaging with global opinion leaders and intellectuals to foster consensus. The upcoming Chinese edition of *China Through European Eyes* is one

of the most important products of the collaborative exchange between CCG and Professor Brown.

Finally, it is my view that *China Through European Eyes* provides an even deeper layer of meaning—showing that cultural exchange goes both ways. In this sense, this book also serves to encourage further research on Europe. The lack of Chinese understanding of Europe before the modern era means that it would be difficult for us to compile a book similar to *China Through European Eyes*. Our understanding of Europe was fragmented and often based on one-sided views of Western missionaries. Later, China adopted concepts of science and technology as well as the social sciences and humanities from Europe, which drove China's modernization. This one-way flow of information—from China to Europe in the past and from Europe to China today—is what may have led to conflicting sentiments in China toward Europe: one of unconditional admiration and another as a victim left of modern history, the latter manifesting as a strong sense of nationalism in the current international environment.

Today, more than ever, China and Europe need to understand each other as equals, starting with their own similarly long civilizations to seek a “middle place of moderation” that allows for bilateral coexistence, learning from the past to understand the present. To achieve this, we not only need Western scholars like Professor Brown, who have a deep understanding of China, but also Chinese scholars with a comprehensive understanding of Europe. Through the process of exchange, understanding, and inclusion, both sides will take Sino-European relations to the next level.

Promoting a “Positive-Sum Game” for China-US Relations⁷

Our fate is not sealed—the conclusion of renowned scholar Joseph Nye—gives the world hope, as he once again reiterates that relations between China and the US does not have to be a zero-sum game and that we should search for a way to ensure a positive-sum outcome for both countries and the world.

On 7 December 1972, from 29,000 km above the Earth’s surface, humans took the first panoramic photograph of the Earth from space—the Blue Marble—a small blue-green island, the only home for all humanity, floated in the vast black expanse of space. This scene made all the differences, contradictions, disputes, conflicts, cold wars, and hot wars between peoples and nations seem so insignificant. The Earth, which carries all life and the interests of all nations, was nothing more than a glass marble in the universe. This is the image I used to start the preface of my new book *CCG Global Dialogues: Understanding Globalization, Global Gaps and Power Shifts in the 21st Century*. I reiterate this here to dispel a common expectation among readers: do not expect Professor Joseph Nye to discuss whether American soft power is stronger than Chinese soft power, whether China will prevail in a new era of great power competition, or whether the United States will emerge victorious. Instead, the book offers a broader perspective to examine the impact of US-China relations on both nations and the world, so that we can delve more deeply into Professor Nye’s wisdom.

Approximately one-fifth of the twenty-first century has already passed. We have witnessed the evolution of a global model of uni-multipolarity into a new stage of truly multipolarization. Economically, in 2021, the combined GDP (gross domestic product) of China and the United States exceeded 40 trillion dollars, accounting for over 40% of the global total. But we are also witnessing a historic shift in global power from the West to the East—from the United States, the established power and leader of the West, toward China, the emerging power and the center of an Asian rejuvenation. Professor Nye once proposed a thought-provoking question: “how do we manage that power transition from the West to East in a way which is beneficial for all countries and which doesn’t break down into great power rivalries, which are destructive?”⁸ There is no doubt that the “great power competition” mentioned here primarily refers to China and the US, which will be the most important bilateral relationship of the twenty-first century; if managed well, it will benefit both countries and the world; if managed poorly, it will harm the global community.

Facing countless uncertainties, many are puzzled about how this relationship will evolve. In April 2021, during a dialogue with Professor Nye, he introduced his “20-year cycle theory”: the first 20 years after the founding of the People’s Republic of China saw extremely strained bilateral relations between the United States and China, with the two countries at war in Korea; in 1972, Nixon’s visit to China marked

⁷ This is the foreword of the Chinese edition of Joseph Nye Jr.’s *Soft Power and Great-Power Competition*, and adapted for this collection.

⁸ Henry Huiyao Wang in Dialogue with Joseph Nye Jr., “Power Narratives in a Changing World: Implications for US-China Cooperative Rivalry”, April 28, 2021.

the beginning of a 20-year period of improving bilateral relations; after Clinton took office in 1992, bilateral relations remained good, during which China joined the WTO (World Trade Organisation) and deeply integrated into the global economy and international order; following the rise of Trump in 2015–2016, bilateral relations began to deteriorate, and we are midway through the current cycle. Based on this 20-year cycle theory, Professor Nye predicted that US-China relations would begin to improve by 2035. “I hope this doesn’t have to last that long,” he said. I believe many people share this hope. Ultimately, good China-US relations will make the world better, while deteriorating China-US relations make the world uneasy as many countries would rather not have to choose sides. Right now, all we can do is wait and see whether Nye’s 20-year cycle theory will ring true yet again.

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When I first met Professor Nye at Harvard University’s Kennedy School of Government, the China-US relationship had not yet reached the low point that it has today. At that time, US foreign policy was focused on combating terrorism, particularly in the Middle East, following the 9/11 attacks. China had just hosted the Olympics and was celebrating the 10th anniversary of its accession to the WTO.

Professor Nye, with the sharp insight of an international political scientist, had been paying attention to China’s rise for over a decade prior to this. In an article published in 1998, he wrote that the term “China’s rise” was a misnomer, and that “re-emergence” would be more accurate. In late 2005, he published an article in *The Wall Street Journal*, discussing China’s soft power for the first time. According to Professor Nye, a nation’s power comprises “hard power” (economic, military, technological, etc.) and “soft power” (cultural, values, foreign policy, etc., factors affecting its development potential and appeal). The combination of hard and soft power forms “smart power.” He said that the attractiveness of traditional Chinese culture, the popularity of Chinese films and television overseas, the 2008 Summer Olympics, the increasing number of foreign students and tourists to China, as well as China’s tripling of its GDP versus pre-reform levels, its foreign economic aid and open markets, had all greatly increased China’s attractiveness. However, Professor Nye also pointed out that China’s soft power still had a long way to go as “China does not have cultural industries like Hollywood, and its universities are far from the equal of America’s. It lacks the many non-governmental organizations that generate much of America’s soft power.”

In 2009, he published an article stating that China’s soft power was still in the early stages of development, with fundamentally different resources compared to the United States or other developed nations: “These systemic and values-based considerations mean that Chinese soft power may be unfamiliar or unpalatable to those outside the Chinese system. However, China as a rising power is attractive in the developing world, which makes it a force that cannot be ignored.” He also discussed the interaction between China and the United States in terms of soft power for the first time, saying that although most Americans assume a zero-sum perspective and cast a more negative, rather than positive, light on China’s soft power growth, “there

is little evidence that an increase in Chinese soft power would unbalance American soft power.” He noted that, “the perception that the Chinese model of combining a market economy with one-party rule (the Beijing Consensus) will challenge the Western model (open markets, democracy, and rule of law), and values are dubious,” “the soft power interaction between the United States and China thus need not be seen as a competition, but rather as a more complex combination of competitive and cooperative forces.”

In 2012, Professor Nye visited China and gave a lecture on soft power at Peking University. In his speech, he humbly noted that while he first proposed the concept of “soft power” over 20 years ago, that type of power had long existed throughout human history and been applied unconsciously. He noted that it was implicit in Lao-tsu’s writings when he says that a leader is best not when people obey his commands, but when they barely know he exists. He noted that soft power is not unique to the United States, and that traditional Chinese culture is the source of China’s soft power. The values that Confucianism respects, such as social harmony, propriety, filial piety, and compassion, have influenced most of East Asia. As Henry Kissinger wrote, “In the Chinese version of exceptionalism, China did not export its values but let others come to seek them.” Additionally, China’s remarkable economic achievements are another major source of its soft power. Over the past 40 years, China has lifted hundreds of millions of people out of poverty, making the country attractive and influential, and winning the admiration of other countries. But he also noted that “China’s economic success has generated both hard and soft power, but within limits.”

In 2019, Professor Nye visited China to attend a seminar hosted by Ogilvy. During a break, he discussed how Chinese companies going global could enhance China’s soft power, provided they establish their brands overseas and improve compliance. As this was an important focus for CCG as well, Professor Nye and I continued to discuss the interaction between the images of multinational companies and national soft power during lunch.

Professor Nye has long held the view that soft power has a positive-sum dimension, where both sides can benefit simultaneously—though this is not always the case, it is possible under certain circumstances. In our dialogue in the spring of 2021, he reiterated his view that soft power doesn’t have to be zero-sum, and gave an example: if China becomes more attractive in the United States, and the United States becomes more attractive in China—it could help both of us overcome our differences—and I couldn’t agree more. This dialogue took place nearly three years after Trump launched his trade war against China, with multiple confrontations taking China-US relations to a low point and placing it at a historic crossroads as the Biden administration had just taken office, and its China policy remained unclear. The international political landscape has undergone a major reversal in just a few years, with buzzwords like “China threat” and the “Thucydides’s Trap” becoming household concepts.

After taking his office, Trump changed Obama's China policy, and since 2017 Washington has shifted its priority from the Middle East to Asia, focusing increasingly on great power competition. So, the question is, what is the next step in China-US competition? As China becomes stronger economically and militarily, how will the United States respond? Will an arms race break out between China and the US? Will the United States form alliances like those formed during the Cold War and define China as its primary rival? How will the United States respond to China's continued advances in technology? Will the United States accept China becoming the world's largest economy and leading technological innovator? Or will the United States view China as its primary strategic rival and try to limit its economic and technological development?

Over these questions looms the shadow of the Thucydides's Trap. China's increasing strength has caused concern and anxiety in the United States. Over the past 30 years, Professor Nye has written extensively on the nature of power and US-China relations. From a historical perspective, the fundamental reason for the changes in bilateral relations is China's continued rise, but beneath the surface lie new adjustments and turmoil triggered by shifts in power. Professor Nye believes that the rise of an emerging power can instill fear in an established power, which may be the root of conflict, but it does not necessarily mean that they have to fall into the "trap." China is not an existential threat to the United States, nor is the United States an existential threat to China.

He also dislikes using terms like "new Cold War" to describe US-China relations, as this is a misperception of history. Today's great power competition cannot be defined using old concepts from the twentieth century due to the greater degree of economic, social, and ecological interdependence between China and the United States compared with the Soviet Union. The correct approach is to strengthen existing social links, such as student exchanges, tourism, and cultural exchanges, and to make progress in economic exchanges, preventing decoupling in some areas from leading to costly economic decoupling. Ultimately, the broader US-China relationship must be managed to avoid miscalculations and unintended consequences. According to the 20-year cycle theory, US-China relations should begin to improve by 2035, but Professor Nye also believes that intense competition between the two countries is inevitable and is likely to continue for 20 years. How, then, can the competition between these two great powers be managed to ensure that the relationship remains healthy and does not become destructive?

* * *

First, we must take the challenges that China and the United States are facing in the twenty-first century very seriously.

In April 2021, during a dialogue with Professor Graham Allison, who brought up the example of the "Thucydides's Trap," we discussed the three objective realities facing both sides: MAD (Mutually Assured Destruction) status brought by nuclear weapons, threats of climate change, and how to decouple without weakening either China or the United States. One way to break this deadlock is to recognize that

cooperation between China and the United States is possible despite the intense competition between the two.

Some politicians and analysts think that the United States and China have entered a “new Cold War,” but Professor Nye argues that this puts China into an ideological framework while ignoring the real strategic challenges both countries face. He argues that even if the two countries were to decouple, they could not avoid an ecological interdependence, which follows from simple physical constraints, not political ones. He argues that there is no need for the countries to get caught up in a new Cold War, let alone a destructive hot war. Over the next 40 years, as China becomes stronger, both countries will need to adjust to a new normal. Nye points out that the United States and China should maintain the current “cooperative rivalry” and once quoted the former Australian Prime Minister Kevin Rudd, who said that US-China competition would be managed competition because it would be non-lethal in nature.

At nearly every opportunity, Professor Nye emphasized two key points: “power with” and “positive-sum,” firmly believing that the world will continue to remain interconnected because of the fact that isolationism is impractical, and the only way forward is through cooperation and engagement. In his book *Do Morals Matter? Presidents and Foreign Policy from FDR to Trump*, he discussed how a country cannot merely seek “power over” others but must also consider “power with” other countries. Today’s information revolution and globalization are profoundly transforming global politics. When facing global challenges such as the COVID-19 pandemic and climate change, power can be a “positive-sum game.” Exercising power *with* other nations in addressing global issues also helps a country achieve its own objectives. Both American and Chinese leaders must recognize this. He urged the United States and China to avoid demonizing each other and believed that if both countries could make themselves more attractive in each other’s eyes, the probability of destructive conflict between them would decrease considerably. If an increase in Chinese soft power can reduce the potential for conflict, it will naturally become part of a “positive-sum relationship.” This is the conclusion Professor Nye came to after a life of research and one that he included as the main theme of this book.

The Center for China and Globalization, which I founded in 2008, has dedicated itself to enhancing China’s soft power. I agree with Professor Nye’s assertion that “a country’s soft power primarily stems from civil society.” Here, I propose that Chinese civil society—whether individuals, businesses, think tanks, or other organizations—should work to promote friendly relations between China and the outside world, understand the differences in values and cultures between the East and West, and act with mutual respect, humility, and confidence when engaging with the world, creating a positive impression.

From the Chinese perspective, if we work harder to actively engage in “track-two diplomacy,” maintain regular exchanges with Western experts, scholars, and business and political elites, hold international forums and create multilateral organizations with international institutions, we can set the agenda in the international public opinion arena, lead the public narrative, build consensus, and unite and expand the scope of those who understand and support China. Over the years, CCG has been actively engaged in multilateral international forums, participating in events such as

the Munich Security Conference and the Paris Peace Forum, and hosting sub-forums. We have launched the “CCG Global Dialogue” program, featuring exchanges with international opinion leaders and experts such as Angus Deaton, Thomas Friedman, Martin Wolf, Pascal Lamy, John Thornton, Kishore Mahbubani, Tony Saich, Neil Bush, David Lampton, Stephen Roach, Jim O’Neill, and dozens of other international opinion leaders and experts. In 2021, CCG also launched the “Global Young Leaders Dialogue Project” (GYLD), which works to create a platform for dialogue among youth from different countries and backgrounds. To mark the one-year anniversary of GYLD, representatives sent a letter to President Xi Jinping describing their experiences in China and received a reply, a rare honor and recognition of their efforts. Our efforts have placed CCG among the top 100 global think tanks in the University of Pennsylvania’s Global Think Tank Index for several consecutive years, and we were the first Chinese think tank to be awarded special consultative status by the United Nations EOCSOC.

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Reading this book, careful readers will find that some articles are written from the American perspective. In the first article of Part One, Professor Nye discusses how the concept of “soft power” originated as a rebuttal to the then-prevalent theory of American decline. In Part Two, he discusses soft power and American foreign policy from the perspective of American interests. But at the same time, he has also published articles criticizing the Trump administration’s “America First” strategy, arguing that it undermines American soft power and decreases America’s attraction in the eyes of other countries and people around the world.

In the third and fourth parts, we find that Professor Nye’s discussion is rooted in American national interests and with a bird’s-eye view. Adhering to scholarly neutrality, he adopts a broad perspective on the impact of Sino-US competition and cooperation on both countries, the world, and the future, looking beyond the surface to grasp the essence of the problem and propose solutions or recommendations.

US-China relations have weathered many storms and progressed through twists and turns. In this historic period of profound change, the old international order is undergoing significant change, and the creation of a new international order will face numerous challenges. Regardless of the roles the two countries play in this process, one thing is certain: challenges presented by technology and the environment must be addressed through bilateral cooperation. The harm caused by climate change may far exceed the destruction brought by war. The COVID-19 pandemic, which claimed millions of lives, will not be the last major pandemic humanity will face. The meeting between President Xi Jinping and President Biden in Bali where the leaders discussed strategic issues in China-US relations and major global and regional issues, as well as talks in Langfang, have sent positive signals. I believe that while the specter of the Thucydides’s Trap has loomed over human history for the past 2500 years, an ancient Roman proverb can also be used to explain the current geopolitical situation and possibly counteract Thucydides’ curse: if your neighbor is wealthy, you are likely to become wealthy as well; if your neighbor is poor, you will not become wealthy

either. In the global village, countries are neighbors, and both sides of the Pacific can benefit from each other’s growth, and other countries also can benefit from that healthy relationship. Let us not forget that we all live on the same big blue dot.

Joseph Nye is no stranger to Chinese readers. His co-authored works, *Understanding Global Conflict and Cooperation: An Introduction to Theory and History*, *Power and Interdependence* and *The Oxford Handbook of International Relations* have been translated into Chinese and reprinted multiple times as university textbooks. The Chinese edition of his monographs *Soft Power: The Means to Success in World Politics*, *The Powers to Lead* and *The Future of Power* were published by CITIC Press, sparking a boom in soft power research and discussion in China. Additionally, his other works such as *Is the American Century Over?* and *Do Morals Matter?* have also garnered significant attention from the academic community in China.

The successful publication of Professor Nye’s book *Soft Power and Great-Power Competition* is thanks to the hard work of the staff at CITIC Press. I hope that readers will be able to appreciate the development of his ideas and his stable perspective amid such radical changes as they read his articles based on more than 30 years of research on power and China-US relations.

Furthermore, I would like to thank the translation team for this book: Li Yanjie (translator of “Dialogue” and Part One), Bai Ruixia (translator of Parts Two and Four), Bai Yunfeng (translator of Part Three), and Ren Yuyuan, who reviewed the entire translation manuscript.

I would like to conclude this preface with a quote from Professor Nye’s article “China and the United States: Looking Forward 40 Years”: “There is no single future until it happens. The fate of the United States, of China, or of the world as a whole is not yet sealed.” Indeed, the destinies of the United States, China, and the world depend on the choices and actions we make today.

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